Jude 17–23 — Leader / Learner Guide

The Believer's Response: Build, Pray, Keep, Rescue · Study 5 of 6 · Source: The Gospel Vault

Big Idea and Context

> **Big idea:** After the warnings, Jude gives the beloved a way of life: remember, build, pray, keep themselves in God's love, wait for Christ's mercy, and reach out with mercy fitted to each person.

The turn comes at "But you, beloved." The letter moves from the intruders to the faithful.

- **vv. 17–19:** remember the apostles.
- **vv. 20–21:** four disciplines.
- **vv. 22–23:** three rescue postures.
- **vv. 24–25:** He is able.

Four Disciplines and Three Postures

Verse	What it says	Teaching point
v. 20	build · pray	Build on the most holy faith; pray in the Holy Spirit.
v. 21	keep · wait	Keep yourselves in God's love; wait anxiously for Christ's mercy to eternal life.
v. 22	mercy	Have mercy on some, who are doubting.
v. 23	rescue · caution	Snatch some from the fire; have mercy with fear on others.

Keeping: God keeps believers (v. 1); believers keep themselves in His love (v. 21). Free Grace reads the second as a call to walk in what is already true; Reformed writers often see it as a means of perseverance.

Teaching Flow

1. **Remember (vv. 17–19).** The apostles said this would happen.
2. **Build, pray, keep, wait (vv. 20–21).** One posture of life.
3. **Three postures (vv. 22–23).** Wavering, endangered, deeply stained.

Clarify While Teaching

- **Textual variants (vv. 22–23):** some manuscripts have two groups, others three. The NASB follows three.
- **"Save" (v. 23):** a broad word; here, rescue from present danger. Many Reformed writers read eternal salvation.
- **"Eternal life" (v. 21):** its fullness, completed at Christ's appearing; believers already have it (John 5:24).
- **Polluted garment:** Lev. 13; Zech. 3:3–4.

Discussion and Close

1. Which of the four disciplines needs more attention in your life?
2. Who do you know who needs one of the three kinds of mercy? Which kind?
3. How does waiting for Christ's mercy change how you carry pressure?

Close: Point ahead to vv. 24–25: the letter ends not with an instruction but with praise: He is able.